POLIS — Player's Manual

A real-time strategy game for the Amstrad CPC 6128REVIVE8BIT · 2026 · VASPER



1. The idea

You start with a Town Center and three villagers, and no soldiers. The villagers gather food, wood, gold and stone. You spend these resources on buildings, new units, technologies and new ages, and your *polis*, a city-state, grows. An enemy city in another corner of the map starts the same way and does the same. It gathers, builds, raises an army and sends it against you in waves.

The map is 96 × 96 tiles, about thirteen screens. You see it in isometric view, and what your people have not explored yet stays black.

2. Loading the game

Insert the disc, type the command below and press **RETURN**. The title screen appears after a few

seconds.

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RUN"POLIS
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The game needs a CPC 6128, or another CPC with 128 KB. The disc must **not** be write-protected, because saved games and campaign progress are written to it.

3. The tutorial



Choose **TUTORIAL** in the menu if you are new to Polis. Herodotus, the father of history, appears in a window in the middle of the screen and explains the next step. The game waits while he speaks. Press **RETURN** (Enter on a PC) to close the window, then do what he asked. When you have done it, he explains the next step:

1. select a villager;
2. gather berries;
3. build a House;
4. train a villager at the Town Center;
5. build Barracks;

6. train a swordsman;
7. march on the enemy city.

The enemy plays normally during the tutorial, but its first wave comes only after 15 minutes.

4. The main menu

key	action
↑ / ↓	move the arrow
← / →	on PLAY AS: choose the culture
RETURN, **SPACE**, **COPY** or **ENTER**	choose

- **PLAY AS ‹culture›** starts a free game against the computer.
- **GREEK CAMPAIGN** and **EGYPTIAN CAMPAIGN** each have four levels (see section 11).
- **TUTORIAL** teaches you the game step by step (see section 3).
- **LOAD GAME** continues the game you saved with **V**. If there is no saved game, a new one starts.

There are eight cultures: Egyptians, Greeks (the default), Babylonians, Asians, Romans, Persians, Phoenicians and Celts. They play the same way. From the Bronze Age on, each culture's buildings have their own look.

5. The screen



The top of the screen is the world. The panel at the bottom is the HUD.

- **Top row of the HUD:** food, wood, gold, stone, population, and the current age.
- **Left of the HUD:** the **mini map**. It shows the whole land as far as you have explored it, and the frame that marks where the camera is.
- **Card next to the mini map:** when a building is selected, the card shows how many units wait in its queue (the digit). The bar under the digit shows the progress of the current unit, of the construction, or of the research.

When the game ends, the card shows the result: a **red flag** means you won and a **skull** means you lost.

6. Controls

key	action
Q A O P or joystick	move the cursor (at the edge of the screen the map scrolls)

key	action
cursor keys	scroll the map
SPACE or fire	select: a click picks the unit under the cursor; hold and drag for a box
RETURN, **ENTER**, **COPY** or fire 2	command the selected units (see below)
C H B G S M R L F W	with villagers selected: choose a building to place
N K D	the same, for the Bronze Age buildings
RETURN or **ENTER**	while placing: build here
ESC	cancel the placement
T	with a building selected: train a unit
U	with a building selected: research its next technology
V	save the game to disc (about 2 seconds)

On a PC emulator, **RETURN** is the main **Enter** key. The CPC's **ENTER** (on the numeric keypad) is the keypad Enter, and does the same everywhere.

What RETURN does

What happens depends on what is under the cursor.

- **Empty ground:** the selected units walk there, in four columns.
- **Berry bush, tree, gold or stone:** the selected villagers go and gather it.
- **An enemy unit** (red): attack it.
- **An enemy building:** attack it until it falls.

Villagers carry their load to the nearest drop site:

- the Town Center takes everything;
- the Granary takes food;
- the Storage Pit takes wood, gold and stone.

Swordsmen and archers attack any enemy that comes near, as long as they are not carrying out an order of yours. A villager who is attacked fights back.

7. Buildings

To build, select one or more villagers, press the building's key, move the corner of the cursor to the spot, and press **RETURN**. The cost is paid at once and a foundation appears. The selected villagers walk to it and build. When the building is finished, you hear a tone.

key	building	cost	needs	what it does
C	Town Center	200 wood	–	villagers, drop site for all, the new ages
H	House	30 wood	–	+5 population
B	Barracks	125 wood	–	swordsmen
G	Granary	120 wood	–	drop site for food; Domestication
S	Storage Pit	120 wood	–	drop site for wood, gold, stone; weapons and armour
M	Market	150 wood	Granary	the gathering technologies
R	Archery Range	150 wood	Barracks	archers; Archery, Composite Bow
L	Stable	150 wood	Barracks	needed for the Academy
F	Farm	75 wood	Market	when built, 3 × 3 field plots, 40 food each
W	Tower	150 stone	Granary	
N	Temple	200 wood	Bronze Age	Medicine
K	Government Center	200 wood	Bronze Age, Market	
D	Academy	200 wood	Bronze Age, Stable	hoplites; Phalanx

To select a building, click on it with **SPACE**. **T** puts one unit in its queue, and the queue holds up to five. The cost is paid when you press the key.

Population: you can have up to 15 people, plus 5 for each House.

8. Units

unit	from	cost	health	attack	
Villager	Town Center	50 food	25	3	gathers and builds

unit	from	cost	health	attack	
Swordsman	Barracks	35 food, 15 gold	60	8	close combat
Archer	Archery Range	40 food, 20 wood	35	6	shoots arrows from a distance
Hoplite	Academy	60 food, 40 gold	90	10	the heavy infantry of the Bronze Age

A unit standing behind a building is shown as an outline in its team's colour, so you never lose sight of it.

9. Ages and technologies

The game starts in the **Tool Age**. Select the Town Center and press **U** to advance:

- **Bronze Age:** 800 food. It unlocks the Temple, the Government Center and the Academy. The buildings of your culture take their new look.
- **Iron Age:** 1000 food and 800 gold, in the Bronze Age.

U on any other building researches the first of its technologies that you can have now. The bar of the card shows the progress.

building	technology	cost	effect
Granary	Domestication	200 food, 50 wood	villagers carry +5 food
Market	Woodworking	120 food, 75 wood	+5 wood carried
Market	Gold Mining	100 food, 120 wood	+5 gold carried
Market	Stone Mining	100 food, 50 stone	+5 stone carried
Storage Pit	Toolworking	100 food	swordsman attack +2
Storage Pit	Leather Armour	75 food	swordsman health +10
Storage Pit	Metallurgy *(Bronze, after Toolworking)*	200 food, 120 gold	swordsman attack +3
Storage Pit	Scale Armour *(Bronze, after Leather Armour)*	100 food, 50 gold	swordsman health +15
Archery Range	Archery	100 food, 50 wood	archer attack +2
Archery Range	Composite Bow *(Bronze, after Archery)*	180 wood, 100 gold	longer range
Temple	Medicine	120 food, 60 gold	villager health +10

building	technology	cost	effect
Academy	Phalanx	150 food, 100 gold	hoplite health +20

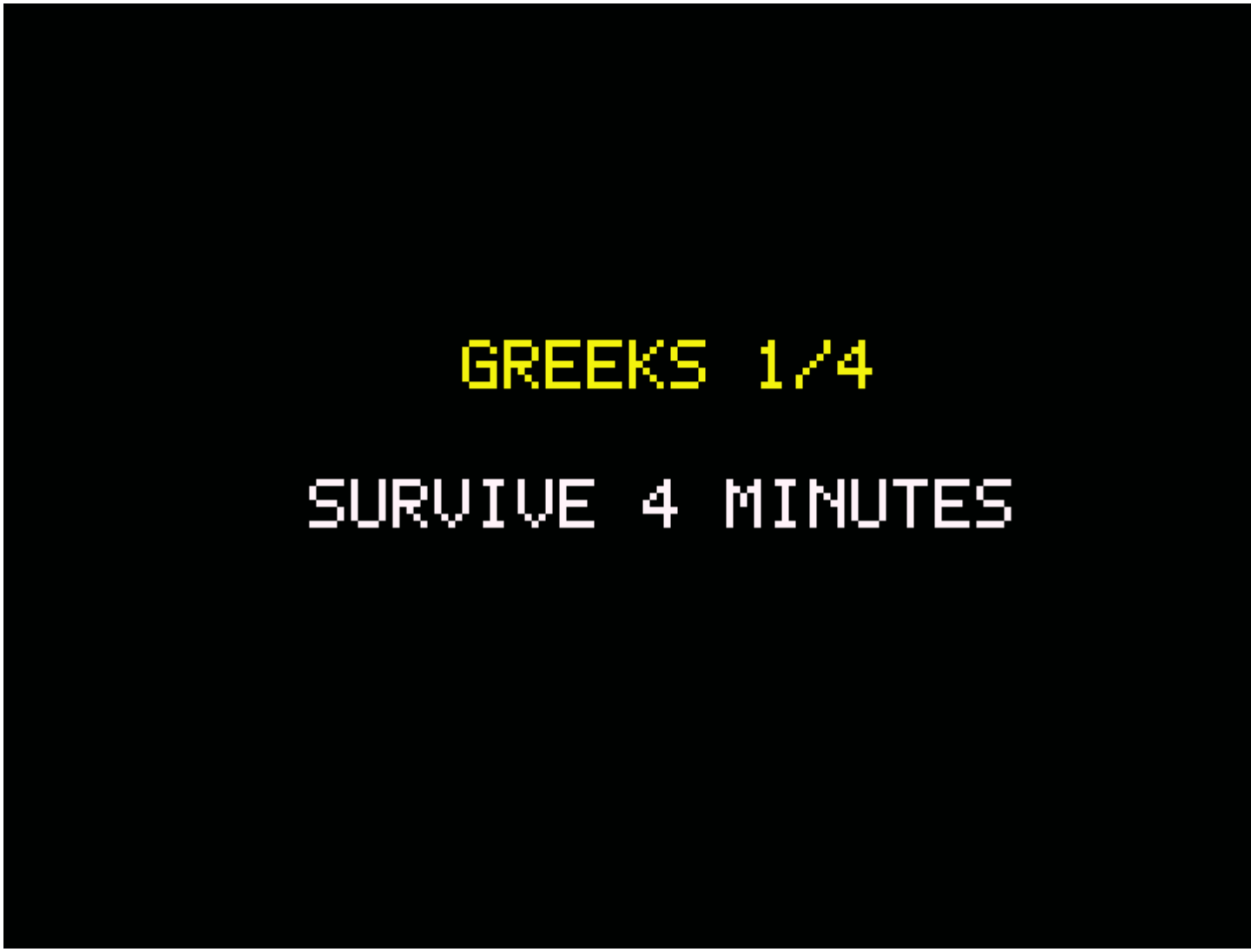
10. The enemy, victory and defeat

The enemy plays red. It gathers, builds Houses and Barracks, trains soldiers and sends them against your Town Center in waves. In a single game (PLAY) the first wave of 6 soldiers comes after 5 minutes; every next one is two soldiers bigger, a minute apart at least. When one of your units is struck, you hear a warning, at most once every ten seconds.

You **lose** when you have no units and no Town Center left. The enemy loses the same way. When the game ends, it stops, and the card next to the mini map shows a red flag (victory) or a skull (defeat).



11. The campaigns



Before each level, a screen shows its goal. Press a key to start.

- When you **win**, the progress is written to the disc and the next level loads by itself.
- When you **lose**, the same level starts again.
- The campaign remembers where you stopped, even after you switch the computer off.
- After the fourth level, the campaign starts again from the first.

	Greeks	Egyptians
1	Survive 4 minutes	Gather 300 gold
2	Gather 400 gold	Survive 5 minutes
3	Reach the Iron Age	Destroy the city
4	Destroy the city	Reach the Iron Age

You also win any level if you destroy the enemy completely.

12. Tips

- Put the three villagers to work at once: two on berries, one on wood. Have the Town Center train more right away.
- Build a House early, because a full population stops all training.
- You have no army at the start. Build Barracks before the first wave arrives. Keep the soldiers between the Town Center and the road the enemy comes on.
- Build Granaries and Storage Pits next to the resources. Short trips mean more food and wood.
- Save often with **V**.